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GUILFORD COUNTY DATA ATLAS PROJECT

Concentrated Disadvantage and the Geography of Opportunity

A Demographic and Socioeconomic Profile of Target Census Tracts in
Greensboro and High Point, Guilford County, North Carolina

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Abstract

This report presents a comparative demographic and socioeconomic analysis of nine census tracts in Guilford County, North Carolina with four located in the city of High Point (Census Tracts 138, 139, 142, and 143) and five in the city of Greensboro (Census Tracts 11201, 11202, 113, 114, and 115). These tracts were selected by Innovative Research Insights, LLC (IRI) and the Guilford County Register of Deeds as the focal geography for the Guilford County Data Atlas initiative, an effort to document neighborhood-level conditions, identify economic development opportunities, and inform targeted public and private investment.

Drawing on 2025 American Community Survey estimates and 2022–2023 supplemental expenditure and employment data, this report documents patterns of demographic concentration, concentrated poverty, educational disadvantage, labor market exclusion, housing instability, inadequate household resources, and structural disinvestment that together constitute the socioeconomic landscape within which community revitalization efforts must operate. Interwoven throughout the report are data from local scholarly studies to provide depth and character to the statistical data.

The analysis situates these neighborhoods within the broader county context and engages relevant sociological frameworks, including Wilson’s (1987) theory of concentrated disadvantage, Massey and Denton’s (1993) analysis of residential segregation, research on corporate investor homebuying (Raymond et al., 2021), and contemporary perspectives on place-based inequality, to interpret the data and identify pathways for equitable economic development.

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The Structural Roots of Concentrated Disadvantage

The neighborhood conditions documented in this report did not arise by accident, nor are they the natural product of an impartial housing market. They are the cumulative, legible residue of more than a century of deliberate policy, racialized planning practices that allocated opportunity to some neighborhoods and burden to others, and that continue to shape the life chances of residents long after the laws that created them were struck from the books. Before turning to the contemporary data, this introduction establishes the historical and structural frame that gives those data meaning. It synthesizes companion works authored by Dr. Sills at the UNC Greensboro Center for Housing and Community Studies and Innovative Research Insights including a whitepaper entitled “From Disparity to Parity: Unveiling the Impact of Racial Planning and Segregation on High Point’s Black Community and the Roadmap to Resolution” (Sills, 2023). These works trace a single argument: that the geography of disadvantage in Guilford County is, in significant measure, the geography of racial exclusion given spatial form, and that any serious strategy for equitable investment must begin from that recognition.

The Architecture of Racialized Planning

In the early 1800s, Black and white residents of the South typically lived in close physical proximity, albeit under clear social and legal separations (Sills, 2021). As cities grew through the mid-1800s and after the Civil War, distinct Black enclaves began to form, frequently in the least desirable zones of the urban landscape, near railroad tracks, cemeteries, factories, and land with poor drainage. The legal scaffolding of formal segregation was assembled over the decades that followed. The Civil Rights Act of 1875 was struck down by the Supreme Court in 1883, and the 1896 *Plessy v. Ferguson* decision entrenched the doctrine of “separate but equal,” accelerating a sorting of Southern cities into separate commercial, educational, religious, and recreational spaces (Sills, 2021; Massey & Denton, 1993).

Racial zoning and racially restrictive covenants became the central instruments of containment. Although the Supreme Court invalidated race-based zoning in *Buchanan v. Warley* (1917) and declared restrictive covenants judicially unenforceable in *Shelley v. Kraemer* (1948), planners and elected officials substituted indirect mechanisms, single-family zoning, restrictive building codes, and neighborhood improvement associations, that achieved the same exclusionary ends (Sills, 2021; Rothstein, 2017). Federal policy then institutionalized these practices at scale. In the 1930s, the Home Owners’ Loan Corporation introduced redlining, grading neighborhoods from A (most desirable) to D (least desirable) and using race as a scoring factor across the 239 cities mapped under its City Survey

Program. Grade D, “redlined,” neighborhoods carried the lowest homeownership rates, the lowest house values, and the highest vacancy rates, conditions that persist in the same geographies today (Sills, 2021).¹

The exclusion compounded across generations. The GI Bill of 1944 promised low-interest mortgages to returning veterans, yet only a fraction of eligible Black veterans secured federally insured loans; had they not been excluded, the post-war period would have produced an estimated 500,000 additional Black homeowners and the intergenerational wealth that homeownership confers (Sills, 2021; Oliver & Shapiro, 1995). Urban renewal, authorized by the Housing Acts of 1949 and 1954, then demolished the physical and institutional fabric of Black communities directly: more than 2,100 projects nationwide cleared over 425,000 housing units, and roughly 80 percent of those displaced were Black (Sills, 2021). The promised benefits, blight removal, improved housing, an expanded tax base, accrued elsewhere; for Black communities the result was further concentration of poverty, the loss of homes, businesses, and churches, and a durable erosion of social and economic capital.

The Enduring Structure of Segregation in Southern Cities

While residential racial segregation was codified as policy in America between roughly 1900 and 1940, its effects have endured despite more than half a century of efforts to dismantle it. Segregation peaked in the 1970s and eased modestly over the two decades that followed; but the most recent decades have seen a return to sorting on the basis of income and race, with suburbanization producing enclaves of wealthy, white residents alongside increasingly isolated urban Black neighborhoods. Geospatial analysis of Southern cities documents a resurgence of racial and ethnic isolation, the resegregation of schools, and a “concentration effect” of poverty and marginalization (Sills, 2021; Massey, 2020).

The central insight of this work is that inequities have become enduringly associated with specific geographies. Where one lives shapes access to good jobs, quality schools, healthy food, clean water, and health-promoting resources. It shapes exposure to crime, environmental hazards, and disinvestment. It also shapes the constrained set of choices available to residents (Sills, 2021; Sampson, 2012; Sharkey, 2013). Place, in other words, is not a neutral backdrop to inequality but one of its mechanisms, a structural condition transmitted across generations. The contemporary tract-level patterns documented later in this report, majority-Black composition layered over concentrated poverty, depressed homeownership, elevated vacancy, and constrained mobility, are precisely the signature this literature predicts.

¹ See also Sills 2021 “Exclusion by Design: from Redlining to Gentrification” <https://chcs.uncg.edu/wp-content/uploads/2021/02/Redlining-Gentrification-and-its-Impacts.pdf>

How Segregation Was Built - The Mechanisms



Source: Sills, S. (2021). Enduring Impact of Racialized Planning in Southern Cities. EPU Policy Brief / UNCG Center for Housing & Community Studies.
<https://chcs.uncg.edu/wp-content/uploads/2022/01/EPU-White-Paper-Dr.-Sills-FINAL-1.pdf>

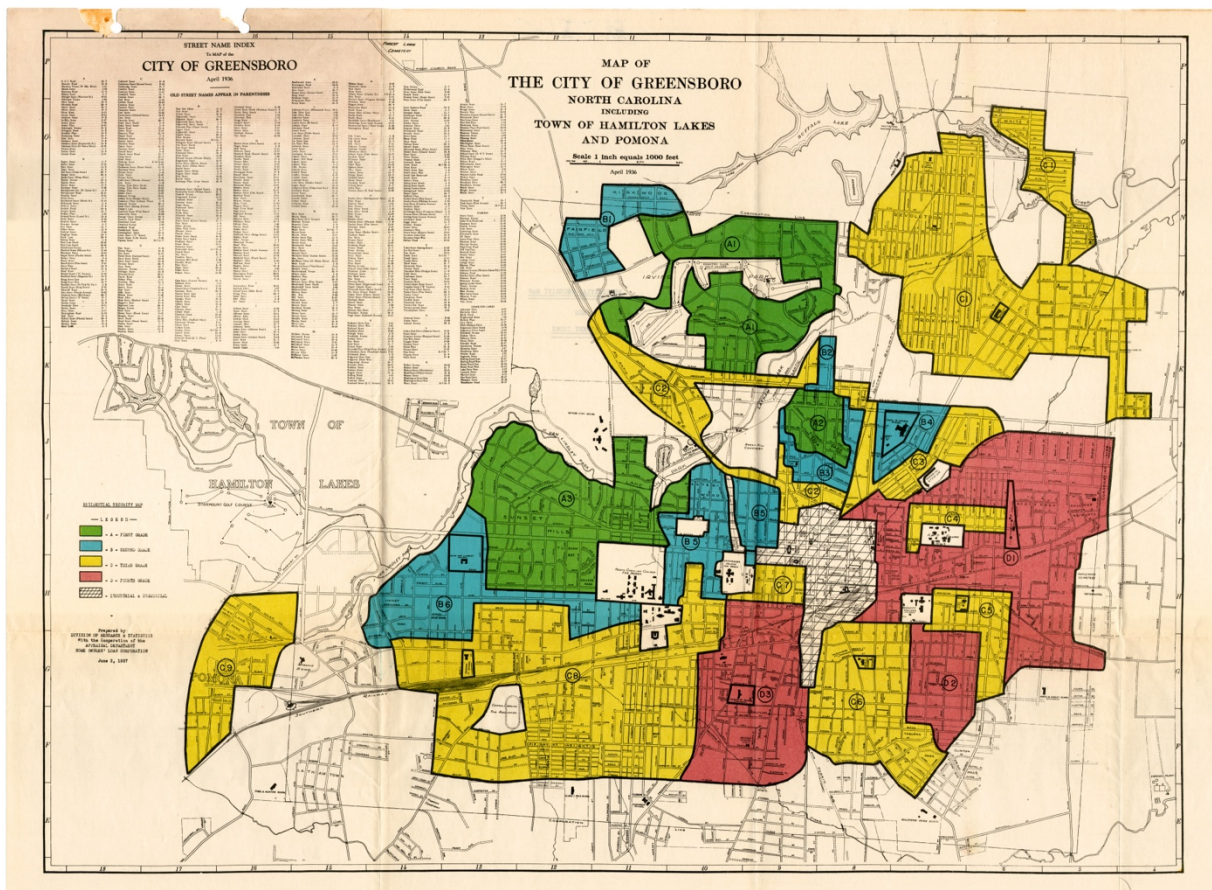
Greensboro: A Dual Market by Design

Founded in 1808 on a 42-acre woodland tract purchased for \$98 from the lawyer Ralph Gorrell, the village grew from a two-block courthouse settlement into a regional commercial hub after the North Carolina Railroad reached it in 1856, and eventually into the state's third-largest city (NCpedia). As the city expanded through Reconstruction, so did its segregated Black neighborhoods; the same ones we examine today as our target census tracts.

What appears at first as opportunity was structured from the outset as containment. In 1867, Yardley Warner, acting on behalf of a Philadelphia Quaker aid organization, purchased

35½ acres south of downtown and subdivided it into one-acre lots sold to Black families so that they could build equity and financial independence. By the turn of the century, Warnersville was an established community of roughly 600 residents anchored by a school, a church, and the Union Cemetery (Preservation Greensboro). Jonesboro near the present-day campus of North Carolina A&T, and later Scott Park, College Heights, and Clinton Hills, constituted what historians have described as a "dual market" in Greensboro: planned, segregated developments that remained the practice through the 1960s (Baylin, 1968).

Even the city's premier Black neighborhood reflected this logic. Nocho Park, platted in 1923 on the former pastureland of the Benbow Dairy as an exclusive development for middle- and high-income Black residents, complete with a planned park, hospital, and school, was the product of white developers (Matheson-Wills Real Estate, in partnership with the Benbow & White agency), underscoring that even aspirational Black communities were created within, rather than outside of, a segregated market (Preservation Greensboro).

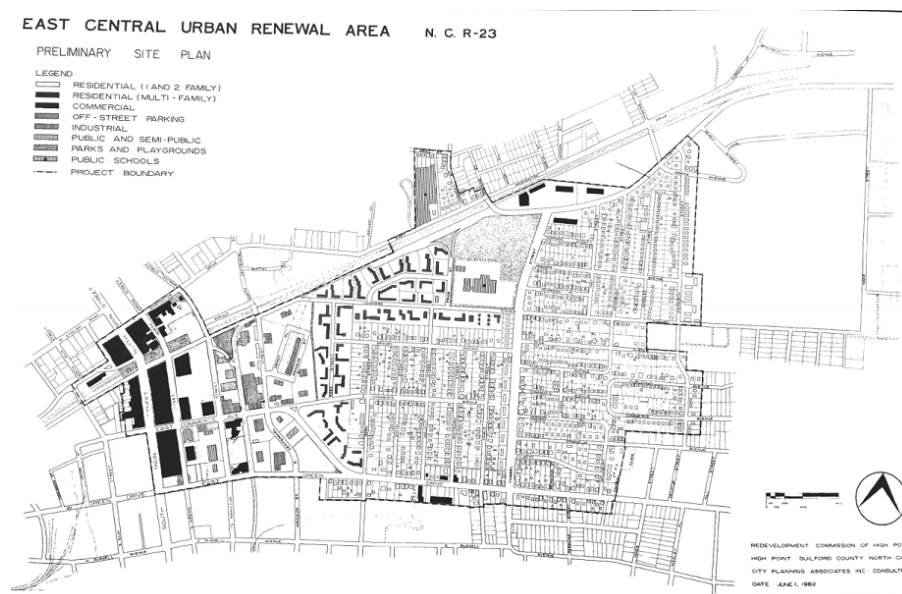


Source: University of Richmond, Digital Scholarship Lab. Mapping Inequality: Redlining in New Deal America. <https://dsl.richmond.edu/panorama/redlining>

These neighborhoods were then systematically devalued and, ultimately, dismantled. The 1937 Home Owners' Loan Corporation map of Greensboro shaded much of Nocho Park, Clinton Hills, and the surrounding Black neighborhoods yellow or red, deeming them "definitely declining" or "hazardous" for investment on the basis of racial composition; the resulting denial of credit left East Greensboro land values vulnerable long before the bulldozers arrived (Preservation Greensboro; Rothstein, 2017). Urban renewal completed the work, as Jonesboro, Warnersville, and other neighborhoods of Black homeowners were cut through and cleared by the construction of U.S. 29, public housing, and allied "renewal" efforts. The 1937 redlining grades still align closely with present-day patterns of social vulnerability, depressed housing markets, concentrated poverty, elevated respiratory illness, and lower life expectancy, a continuity that is, once again, the geography of racial exclusion enduring across a century (Sills, 2021).

High Point: From Disparity to Parity a Case in Point

Founded in 1859 as "the highest point on the line of survey" of the North Carolina Railroad, High Point grew rapidly around furniture and textile manufacturing concentrated in the city core; its first city plan was adopted in 1928, following the Supreme Court's 1926 Euclid v. Ambler Realty decision legalizing zoning (Sills, 2023). The erosion of the manufacturing base since the early 1970s, accelerated by globalization, left many of the homes and neighborhoods built in earlier decades to fall into disuse and disrepair, concentrating urban decay in the historically Black core.



Source: East Central Urban Renewal Area (1962) in Sills, S. J. (2023) From Disparity to Parity: Unveiling the Impact of Racial Planning and Segregation on High Point's Black Community and the Roadmap to Resolution.

Nowhere is this clearer than in the East Central Area of High Point, which corresponds to U.S. Census Tract 139, the very tract that emerges in the analysis below as the most economically distressed in the entire nine-tract sample. East Central was repeatedly targeted for redevelopment “in part based on racial composition of the neighborhood” (Sills, 2023). A 1962 urban renewal plan classified 77 percent of the area’s structures, 1,061 buildings, as deficient and proposed acquisition and clearance and a 1986 East Central Small Area Plan renewed the effort. Yet between 1985 and 1987 the City Council committed only \$331,179 in Community Development Block Grant funds to the area, a sum that fell far short of the rehabilitation and reinvestment the plans envisioned (Sills, 2023). The result, more than half a century later, is a neighborhood in which median household income sits at roughly a quarter of the county median and labor force participation has fallen below one-third. The history is not background to Tract 139’s present condition. The history of such policies is the proximate cause of these socioeconomic outcomes.

That history is also carried in the memory of residents. In the historically Black Washington Street corridor, once known as High Point’s “Black Wall Street,” community leaders describe urban renewal not as benign decline but as deliberate dispossession:

“That started with urban renewal back in the 60s...when they decided to run the [major roadway] on through a black community...that was the downfall of our community...another thing that I feel like would have helped our community if we had that in place was a historical black college. High Point didn’t have that. Winston Salem got it. Greensboro got it. We did not have that.”

— Community leader, Washington Street Needs Assessment (Innovative Research Insights, 2025)

Across the series of High Point studies conducted by Dr. Sills including the 2015 Market Segmentation Study, the 2016 Health Report Card, the 2017 Behavioral Health Study, the 2019 Resilience High Point Needs Assessment, the 2020 Residential Drinking Water Quality Study, the 2022 Assessment of Social Health Drivers, the 2022 HealthySteps Needs Assessment, and the 2023 Guilford County Workforce Needs Assessment, a single structural story repeats. Concentrated poverty, racialized disinvestment, and the informal redlining of the past have produced enduring disparities in health, housing, transportation, education, and economic opportunity, with non-white residents bearing the heaviest burden. Our report to the [One High Point Commission](#), found in closes by framing the path forward in terms of restorative justice and reparations must include: acknowledgment of past harm, legal and policy reform, targeted investment in historically Black neighborhoods, and the meaningful inclusion of residents in the decisions that shape their communities (Sills, Henry, & Emeto, 2023).

Why This History Frames the Present Analysis

The chapters that follow are largely quantitative. They report population, age, race and ethnicity, language, income, poverty, education, employment, housing, transportation, expenditure, digital access, and racial income disparity across nine census tracts. Read in isolation, those numbers can appear as a neutral inventory of deficits. Read against the history sketched here, they read instead as a measurable record of structural processes, of decisions about where capital would flow and where it would be withheld, repeated and compounded over a century. The frameworks invoked throughout this report, Wilson's (1987) account of concentrated disadvantage, Massey and Denton's (1993) analysis of segregation, and Sharkey's (2013) work on the intergenerational transmission of neighborhood conditions, are the scholarly counterparts of the lived history that residents themselves describe. Where the data that follow are paired with the words of community members and the findings of prior Innovative Research Insights studies, the intention is to keep both registers in view at once: the structural and the personal, the statistical and the testimonial. Both are necessary to understand what these neighborhoods are, how they came to be, and what equitable investment will require.

Place, Poverty, & the Architecture of Inequality

The geography of opportunity in American metropolitan areas is rarely accidental. The spatial distribution of poverty, educational disadvantage, economic exclusion, and inadequate public infrastructure reflects decades of deliberate policy choices, from racially motivated residential segregation enforced through restrictive covenants and redlining, to the concentrated suburbanization of public and private investment that followed mid-century urban renewal, to the more recent impacts of corporate investor homebuying on rental markets and neighborhood stability (Rothstein, 2017; Massey & Denton, 1993; Raymond et al., 2021). Guilford County, North Carolina, home to the cities of Greensboro and High Point and a regional economy historically anchored in textiles, furniture manufacturing, and logistics, is no exception to these structural forces.

The nine census tracts examined in this report are not randomly assembled. They represent communities that have been systematically underserved by the market mechanisms and public investments that generate economic mobility elsewhere in the county. Demographic composition in these tracts differs sharply from the county as a whole: residents are majority Black, heavily Hispanic, more linguistically diverse, and overwhelmingly renters rather than homeowners.

Median household incomes in the most economically distressed tracts are less than one-quarter of the county median. Poverty rates in several tracts exceed 50 percent, figures that, in the sociological literature, mark a threshold beyond which the externalities of concentrated disadvantage become self-reinforcing and particularly resistant to individually-targeted interventions (Wilson, 1987; Jargowsky, 1997; Sampson, 2012). Labor force participation rates in some tracts fall 30 or more percentage points below the county average. Housing vacancy rates in several tracts exceed 15 percent, signaling both disinvestment and, potentially, the commercial activation opportunities that the Guilford County Data Atlas is designed to identify.

This report is organized thematically. Following a geographic and demographic overview that includes population, sex, age structure, race and ethnicity, language, and citizenship, it addresses income and economic conditions, poverty, educational attainment, labor force participation and wages, housing tenure and vacancy, transportation access, household expenditures and financial stress, digital equity, and racial disparities in income and opportunity. A concluding section synthesizes these findings in terms of their implications for equitable economic development and targeted public investment. The analysis is intended to serve as a foundational resource for the Guilford County Data Atlas and for policy conversations at the county, city, and neighborhood levels.

As the introduction makes clear, these structural forces are not abstractions in Guilford County; they are documented in a decade of place-based research. A synthesis of studies conducted across High Point between 2015 and 2023 concluded that “the racism inherent in historical planning and zoning practices have led to the current racial and ethnic disparities we see,” with historically Black neighborhoods disproportionately affected by the concentration of industrial land uses and the environmental, health, and economic burdens that followed (Sills, 2023).

Geographic Overview & Population Profile

The nine target census tracts collectively encompass an estimated 34,665 residents as of 2025, distributed across two distinct urban geographies and representing approximately 6.3 percent of Guilford County’s total population of 549,528. In High Point, the four tracts (138, 139, 142, and 143) serve a combined population of approximately 15,065 persons. Census Tract 142 is the most populous at 4,546, followed by Tract 138 at 4,104 and Tract 139 at 4,058. Tract 143 is smaller, at 2,357 residents, but demographically significant. In Greensboro, the five tracts (11201, 11202, 113, 114, and 115) carry a combined population of approximately 19,600 persons, with Tract 114 being the most populous at 5,214 residents.

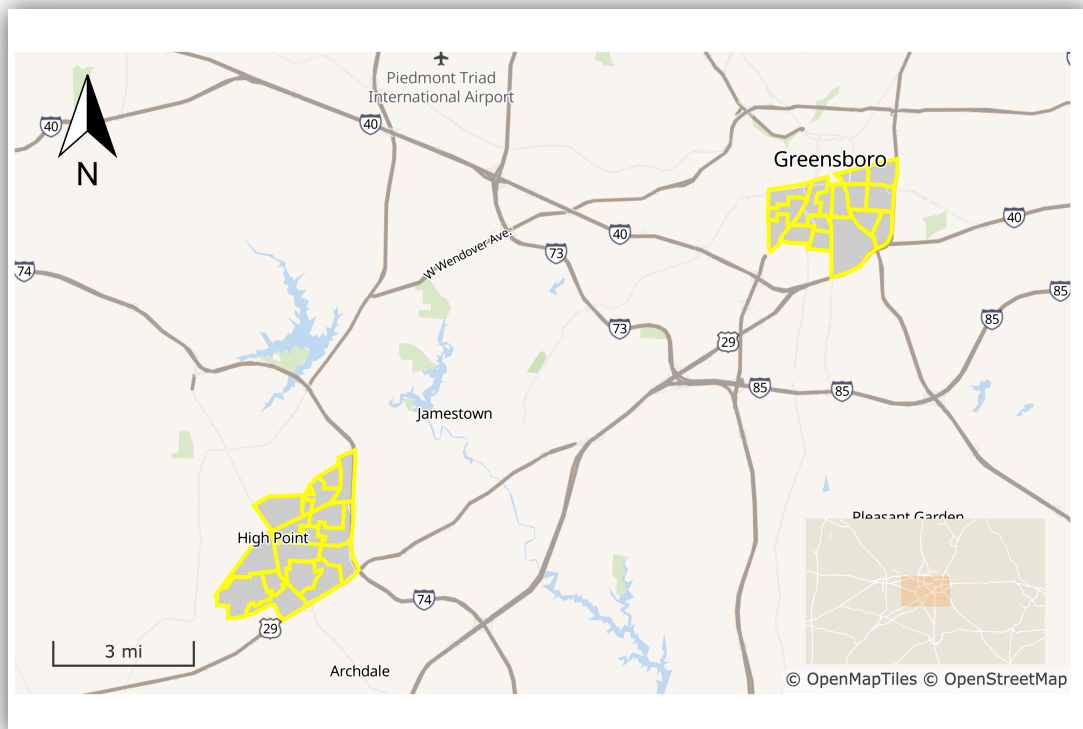


Figure 1 - Nine Target Census Tracts Guilford County, NC

Sex composition of the target tracts reveals several notable departures from the county pattern. Guilford County overall exhibits a modestly female-skewed population (52.4 percent female), consistent with broader national patterns driven by differential life expectancy and post-retirement demographic dynamics. Within the target tracts, however, sex ratios diverge significantly. Tracts 139 (59.4 percent male), 143 (59.9 percent male), and 114 (60.5 percent male) present pronounced male-skewed populations. Conversely, Tracts 11201 (62.8 percent female), 113 (61.2 percent female), and 115 (59.4 percent female) display substantial female skews. Such extreme sex ratios typically reflect the presence of public housing, institutional populations, group homes, correctional facilities, transitional housing, or student dormitories, or the residential effects of differential migration, caregiving burdens, and incarceration rates within specific neighborhoods (Western & Pettit, 2010). Whatever the underlying mechanism, these compositional anomalies have real implications for household formation, child-rearing capacity, and the gendered distribution of economic opportunity within these communities.

Census Tract	City	Total Population	% Male	% Female
138	High Point	4,104	50.4%	49.5%
139	High Point	4,058	59.4%	40.5%
142	High Point	4,546	44.9%	55.1%
143	High Point	2,357	59.9%	39.9%
11201	Greensboro	3,441	37.2%	62.8%
11202	Greensboro	3,418	50.1%	49.9%
113	Greensboro	3,919	38.7%	61.2%
114	Greensboro	5,214	60.5%	39.5%
115	Greensboro	3,608	40.5%	59.4%
Target Area Total	—	34,665	49.2%	50.7%
Guilford County	—	549,528	47.6%	52.4%

Table 1. Population and sex composition, 2025 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS).

Age Structure & Generational Profile

Age distribution is a foundational dimension of neighborhood demographic analysis, carrying implications for school enrollment, labor force composition, health care demand, social service needs, and the intergenerational transmission of neighborhood conditions. The target tracts, taken collectively, exhibit a younger age profile than the county as a whole, with higher concentrations of children under 10 (15.4 percent versus 11.4 percent countywide) and young adults ages 20–34 (26.1 percent versus 20.7 percent). Correspondingly, middle-aged adults (35–54) are somewhat underrepresented (18.5 percent versus 24.4 percent), as are adults 75 and over (4.8 percent versus 6.4 percent).

Beneath these aggregate figures, however, substantial tract-level variation exists. Census Tract 139 (High Point) presents a notable concentration of young children, with 14.9 percent of its population between the ages of 5 and 9, more than double the county rate of 6.0 percent. Census Tract 114 (Greensboro) shows a similar pattern, with 10.1 percent of its population under five and 16.8 percent ages 10–14. These “family communities” with disproportionate shares of young children face particular challenges in the context of concentrated poverty: the sociological and developmental literature is unambiguous that childhood exposure to concentrated disadvantage produces measurable and durable effects on cognitive development, educational attainment, and adult economic outcomes (Sampson, 2012; Sharkey, 2013; Chetty et al., 2016). The investment implications are direct: targeted early childhood programming, school-based supports, and neighborhood-level safety investments in tracts with high child densities represent high-leverage interventions.

At the opposite demographic pole, Census Tract 142 (High Point) displays an unusually older age profile, with 25.9 percent of its residents between the ages of 55 and 64, more than twice the county rate. Combined with another 12.5 percent ages 65 and over, this tract will experience substantial aging into the retirement years within the coming decade. Tract 138 (High Point) similarly exhibits a significant elderly presence (21.4 percent age 65 and over). These aging neighborhoods require investment in accessible housing, transportation services, healthcare access, and anti-isolation community programming.

Census Tracts 11201 and 115 present a third demographic profile, with extraordinary concentrations of young adults aged 18–24. Tract 11201 reports that 52.0 percent of its population falls within this narrow age band, and Tract 115 shows 40.8 percent, figures consistent with the presence of college student housing (NCAT) or similar institutional populations. The demographic weight of this age group reshapes the economic profile of these tracts: consumption patterns, labor market attachment, household formation, and family structure all differ substantially for predominantly student populations, and standard poverty measures for these tracts may overstate the economic precarity of long-term residents while understating that of student households.

The concentration of young children in tracts such as 139 and 114 carries direct developmental stakes. Early brain development research demonstrates that birth to age five is a critical period for language, executive functioning, and emotional regulation, and prior IRI work for Resilience High Point recommended “proactive approaches for serving children in poverty-impacted communities,” including low- or no-cost childcare in target neighborhoods (Sills, 2019). At the other end of the age distribution, the elder-heavy profiles of Tracts 142 and 138 echo a gap that community partners have flagged directly; in the Macedonia neighborhood, a service-provider observed of older residents, “A lot of them are

Census Tract	Under 5	5–17 Years	18–24 Years	25–54 Years	55–64	65+
138 (HP)	5.4%	27.6%	9.0%	29.1%	6.2%	21.5%
139 (HP)	7.6%	16.5%	10.7%	25.4%	25.9%	12.6%
142 (HP)	6.9%	23.5%	10.5%	39.7%	9.2%	9.2%
143 (HP)	3.2%	13.6%	8.4%	52.5%	17.4%	3.6%
11201 (GBO)	1.2%	6.1%	52.0%	20.9%	10.1%	8.9%
11202 (GBO)	8.9%	27.5%	7.7%	36.3%	6.0%	13.3%
113 (GBO)	7.2%	17.6%	9.2%	42.8%	6.5%	15.5%
114 (GBO)	10.4%	30.2%	13.9%	29.2%	5.4%	9.8%
115 (GBO)	4.1%	8.0%	40.8%	26.9%	4.2%	14.7%
Guilford County	5.4%	16.5%	12.4%	37.5%	12.2%	15.9%

Table 2. Age distribution, 2025 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS).

at home alone and may not have family with them. It would be good to have programming for them as well” (Innovative Research Insights, 2025b).

Racial & Ethnic Composition

Race and ethnicity are among the most consequential dimensions of American neighborhood sociology. Residential segregation, the spatial sorting of populations by race, is both a historical legacy of explicit racial exclusion (through restrictive covenants, racial zoning, mortgage redlining, steering, and urban renewal) and a continuing structural feature of contemporary housing markets (Massey & Denton, 1993; Rothstein, 2017; Krysan & Crowder, 2017). The target census tracts analyzed in this report are exemplars of the residential outcomes produced by these structural processes.

Guilford County as a whole is racially heterogeneous, with an estimated 2025 racial composition of 46.1 percent White, 33.9 percent Black or African American, 5.2 percent Asian, and 9.7 percent reporting two or more races, with 10.5 percent of the total population identifying as Hispanic or Latino (who may be of any race). The target tract population inverts this composition dramatically. Collectively, the nine tracts are 59.7 percent Black, nearly twice the county share, and only 16.8 percent White. Hispanic residents constitute 20.1 percent of the target tract population, nearly double the county rate of 10.5 percent.

Several target tracts are overwhelmingly Black. Census Tract 113 (Greensboro) reports 82.7 percent Black residents, Tract 114 (Greensboro) reports 81.1 percent, Tract 142 (High Point) reports 72.1 percent, and Tract 11202 (Greensboro) reports 64.1 percent. These figures exceed thresholds commonly used in the segregation literature to define “racially concentrated areas of poverty”, neighborhoods combining high minority concentration with elevated poverty rates, which the Department of Housing and Urban Development has

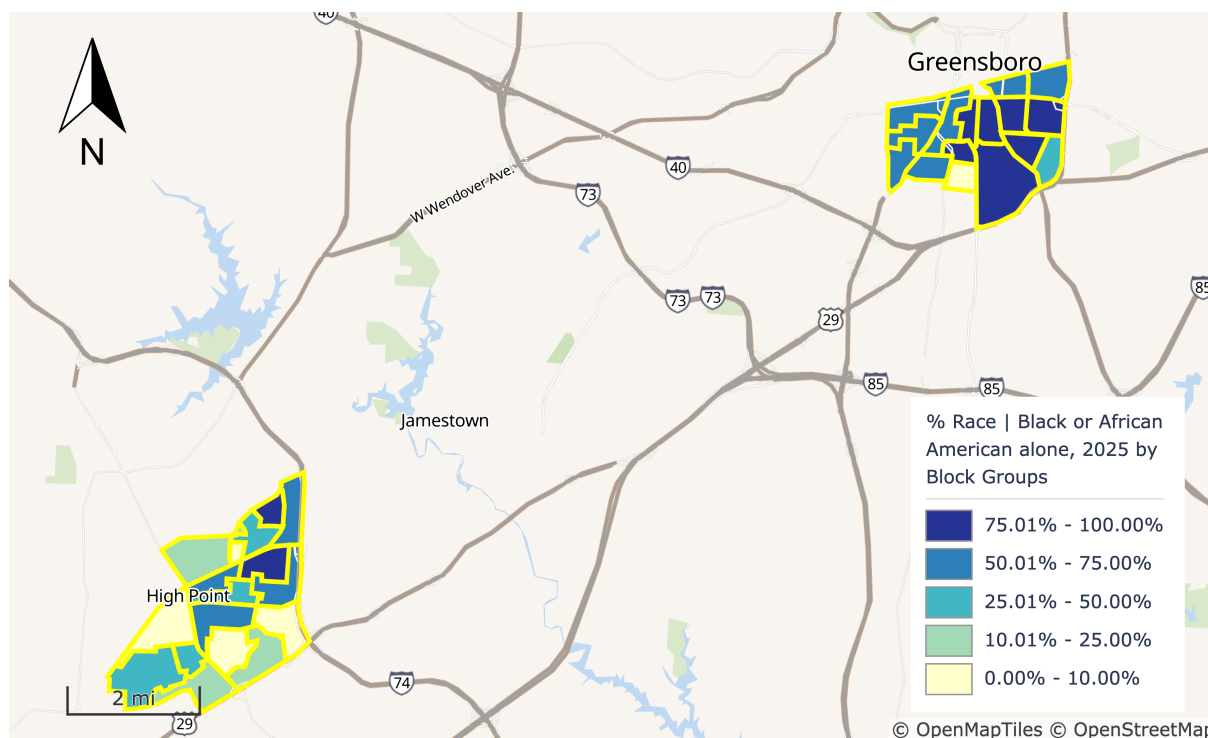


Figure 2 Percent Black ACS Estimates 2025

identified as areas requiring particular attention in fair housing planning (HUD, 2015; Goetz et al., 2019).

Tracts 143 and 11201 present a different compositional pattern. Tract 143 (High Point) is 35.7 percent Hispanic, the highest Hispanic share in the sample, with a relatively diverse racial composition including 13.6 percent Asian residents. Tract 11201 (Greensboro) reports 26.5 percent Asian residents and 25.6 percent Hispanic residents, suggesting a highly diverse neighborhood with a substantial immigrant population. Tract 115 (Greensboro) similarly reports 29.5 percent Hispanic residents alongside 59.4 percent Black residents. The ethnic diversity observed in these tracts represents both an asset, cultural richness, entrepreneurial potential, linguistic capacity, and a challenge for service delivery systems that may not be adequately resourced to serve linguistically and culturally diverse populations.

The racial composition of the target tracts is not incidental to their socioeconomic profile. As Massey and Denton (1993) demonstrated in *American Apartheid*, and as Sharkey (2013) has shown more recently, the intersection of racial segregation and concentrated poverty produces a doubly disadvantaged condition: one in which residents experience not only economic deprivation but also the specific forms of resource denial that attach to racially marginalized neighborhoods, including underfunded schools, reduced business investment, elevated environmental hazards, and diminished political voice. The target

tracts, taken collectively, represent one of the clearest expressions of this dynamic observable in the Guilford County landscape.

Census Tract	% White	% Black	% Asian	% Two+ Races	% Hispanic
138 (HP)	27.5%	54.8%	0.0%	16.5%	27.3%
139 (HP)	6.8%	72.1%	0.0%	10.6%	14.1%
142 (HP)	28.9%	27.1%	13.6%	10.8%	35.7%
143 (HP)	14.3%	29.1%	26.5%	11.2%	25.6%
11201 (GBO)	29.4%	64.1%	2.4%	1.6%	1.9%
11202 (GBO)	4.0%	82.7%	0.0%	9.6%	14.7%
113 (GBO)	13.2%	81.1%	0.3%	5.2%	10.9%
114 (GBO)	7.6%	62.0%	0.0%	18.5%	29.5%
115 (GBO)	19.7%	59.4%	3.5%	5.3%	14.0%
Target Area	16.8%	59.7%	4.2%	10.4%	20.1%
Guilford County	46.1%	33.9%	5.2%	9.7%	10.5%

Table 3. Racial and ethnic composition, 2025 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS). Hispanic/Latino may be of any race.

The spatial concentration these figures describe has a documented history in High Point. The historically Black Washington Street corridor once functioned as the “Main Street” of the African American community, home to dozens of Black-owned establishments and widely remembered as a “Black Wall Street” before the demolitions of the urban-renewal era (Innovative Research Insights, 2025). The persistence of overwhelmingly Black tracts, several exceeding 80 percent Black, alongside the parallel concentration of White homeownership in suburban areas, is a continuation rather than a departure from that history; it is, in Sills’s (2021) terms, evidence of the enduring impact of racialized planning, in which “inequities have become enduringly associated with specific geographies.”

Language, Citizenship, & Nativity

The linguistic and immigration profile of the target tracts further differentiates these neighborhoods from the county as a whole and has direct implications for service delivery, civic participation, and economic opportunity. Of the target tract population aged five and over, approximately 25.5 percent speak a language other than English at home, compared to 16.7 percent countywide. Spanish is the dominant non-English language, spoken at home by 17.1 percent of target tract residents aged five and over, nearly double the county rate of 7.5 percent.

Census Tract 143 (High Point) reports the highest rate of Spanish spoken at home in the sample at 34.5 percent, followed by Tract 11201 (30.3 percent), Tract 115 (28.5 percent), and Tract 138 (16.2 percent). These concentrations reflect the settlement patterns of Latino

populations within specific High Point and Greensboro neighborhoods and suggest significant demand for bilingual service delivery, educational supports for English Language Learners, and culturally competent health and social services. The sociological literature on immigrant incorporation consistently finds that the presence of robust ethnic infrastructure, bilingual services, community organizations, culturally anchored commercial districts, substantially enhances the economic and civic incorporation of immigrant populations (Portes & Rumbaut, 2014).

Citizenship data reinforce the immigrant presence in several target tracts. Countywide, 5.8 percent of residents are not U.S. citizens. Census Tract 11201 (Greensboro) reports 42.1 percent non-citizen residents, an extraordinary concentration that fundamentally shapes the demographic and economic character of that neighborhood. This figure is consistent with the tract's demographic profile, including substantial Asian and Hispanic populations and an unusual age structure dominated by young adults. Tracts 114 (9.2 percent non-citizen) and 142 (7.9 percent non-citizen) also exceed the county baseline. The non-citizen population includes individuals with varying legal statuses, lawful permanent residents, refugees, asylum seekers, holders of temporary protected status, student and work visa holders, and undocumented residents, each facing distinct structural barriers to economic opportunity, healthcare access, and public benefits eligibility (Portes & Rumbaut, 2014; Menjívar, 2006).

Smaller but significant non-English language communities are also visible in the data. Census Tract 11201 reports 13.6 percent of residents speaking “other Asian and Pacific Island languages,” with smaller Chinese-speaking and Arabic-speaking populations also present. Tract 138 reports 12.1 percent of residents speaking German or related West Germanic languages, a linguistic profile that reflects specific migration histories (possibly refugee resettlement) rather than the predominant Hispanic immigration patterns observed elsewhere. Tracts 139 and 138 also show small French-, Haitian-, or Cajun-speaking populations. Such linguistic diversity, while numerically modest in aggregate terms, has significant implications for equitable service delivery: small language communities are often systematically underserved because translation and interpretation services are calibrated to the dominant non-English language, leaving smaller populations without access to critical public information.

Census Tract	% Speak Only English	% Spanish at Home	% Not U.S. Citizen
138 (HP)	67.8%	16.2%	5.4%
139 (HP)	76.8%	12.7%	7.9%
142 (HP)	56.1%	34.5%	5.8%

Census Tract	% Speak Only English	% Spanish at Home	% Not U.S. Citizen
143 (HP)	47.2%	30.3%	42.1%
11201 (GBO)	89.0%	2.3%	1.6%
11202 (GBO)	87.8%	12.2%	8.0%
113 (GBO)	89.1%	2.8%	6.2%
114 (GBO)	70.1%	28.5%	9.2%
115 (GBO)	84.8%	11.9%	2.4%
Guilford County	83.3%	7.5%	5.8%

Table 4. Language spoken at home and citizenship status, 2025 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS).

For many immigrant residents, these neighborhoods are not way stations but homes. Participants in the Resilience High Point study described a community that newcomers actively choose and remain in: “the immigrant community likes High Point. It feels like home. They move into High Point more than they move out” (Sills, 2019). That sense of belonging is an asset for economic development but realizing it requires the bilingual and culturally responsive infrastructure that immigrant incorporation depends upon (Portes & Rumbaut, 2014).

Income & Economic Conditions

Household and per capita income data reveal a profound and systematic divergence between the target census tracts and Guilford County as a whole. The 2025 estimated county median household income of \$67,454 provides a useful baseline. Not a single target census tract approaches this figure; most fall dramatically short of it, and in several cases the income gap represents a chasm that cannot be explained by compositional differences in age or household size alone.

Census Tract 139 in High Point presents the most extreme case of income deprivation in the sample. Its estimated median household income of \$17,692, just 26 percent of the county median, places it among the most economically distressed urban neighborhoods in the state. Average household income in Tract 139 (\$30,453) tells a similar story, approximately 30 percent of the county average of \$102,974. Census Tracts 11201 (\$32,197) and 11202 (\$32,606) in Greensboro, along with Tract 114 (\$33,087) and Tract 115 (\$38,496), cluster in the \$30,000–\$40,000 range, incomes that, for households with children or housing cost burdens in an inflating market, represent genuine material precarity.

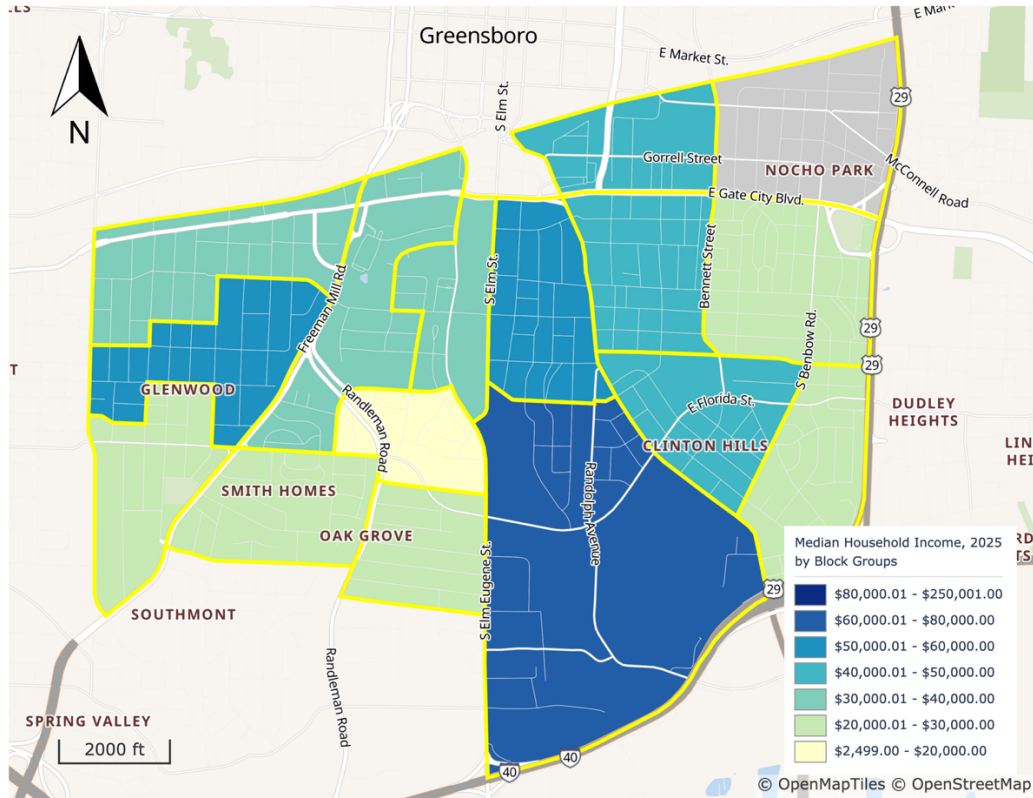


Figure 3 Median Household Income Greensboro Target Tracts

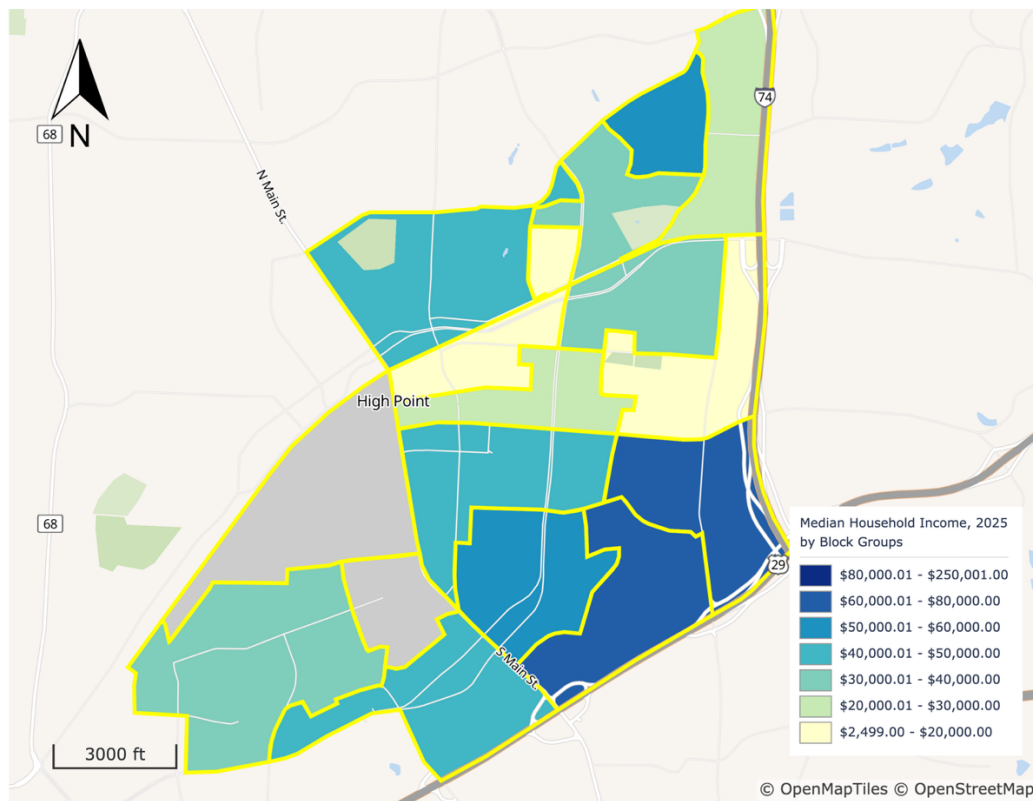


Figure 4 Median Household Income High Point Target Tracts

Census Tract	Median HH Income	Avg HH Income	Per Capita Income	% of County Median
138 (HP)	\$40,923	\$44,818	\$15,965	61%
139 (HP)	\$17,692	\$30,453	\$14,955	26%
142 (HP)	\$50,281	\$75,643	\$21,317	75%
143 (HP)	\$46,894	\$60,058	\$19,755	70%
11201 (GBO)	\$32,197	\$44,335	\$16,911	48%
11202 (GBO)	\$32,606	\$44,294	\$15,886	48%
113 (GBO)	\$55,485	\$69,953	\$28,347	82%
114 (GBO)	\$33,087	\$45,771	\$17,504	49%
115 (GBO)	\$38,496	\$43,971	\$15,769	57%
Guilford County	\$67,454	\$102,974	\$38,793	100%

Table 5. Household and per capita income estimates, 2025 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS).

Per capita income figures reinforce this picture. The county per capita income of \$38,793 is approximately 2.3 times the per capita income of the median target census tract. Tracts 139 (\$14,955), 11202 (\$15,886), 115 (\$15,769), and 138 (\$15,965) all fall below \$16,000 in per capita income, figures consistent with documented poverty-level living standards in the contemporary United States. Even the relatively higher-income tracts, 113 (\$28,347) and 142 (\$21,317), remain substantially below the county average. Tract 113 in Greensboro represents a partial exception, with its average household income of \$69,953 approximating the county median; however, this figure is elevated by higher earners within a tract that nonetheless contains very low-income households and a substantial population in poverty, a pattern consistent with widening intra-neighborhood income inequality.

Detailed household income distribution data clarify the structural shape of economic disadvantage in these tracts. Countywide, approximately 17.4 percent of households report annual income below \$30,000 and 10.2 percent report income of \$200,000 or more. In Census Tract 139, by contrast, 61.1 percent of households fall below \$30,000, with 30.8 percent in the \$10,000–\$20,000 bracket alone. In Tract 11201, 50.7 percent of households are below \$30,000, with 21.9 percent in the \$10,000–\$20,000 bracket. These tracts are effectively bereft of a middle class in the conventional sense: the upper income brackets (\$100,000 and above) are either empty or vanishingly thin, while the lower and very-low income brackets carry the majority of households. Such income compression, in which the neighborhood income distribution is truncated at the top, has consequences beyond the aggregate income figures: it attenuates the diversity of role models, social networks, and economic exchange partners available within the neighborhood, contributing to the social isolation effects documented in the concentrated poverty literature (Wilson, 1987; Sampson, 2012).

These income figures are not merely abstract economic statistics. They have immediate material consequences for the capacity of households to meet basic needs, food, housing, transportation, healthcare, childcare, and for their ability to accumulate the financial reserves that underpin economic mobility across generations (Oliver & Shapiro, 1995; Conley, 1999). At the income levels documented in the most distressed target tracts, the margin between stability and crisis is vanishingly thin, and the pathways to economic security available to households in higher-income portions of Guilford County are largely inaccessible.

The lived texture of these income gaps is sharply visible to those who work in the target neighborhoods. A physician assistant practicing in High Point described how abruptly the income gradient shifts across a single tract boundary:

“High Point is such a unique area, because where my office is we sit in between a very wealthy, affluent type neighborhood, and then going a different direction, a lower socio-economic neighborhood. So exactly within a half a mile difference... we’ve seen a lot more need as far as just sort of basic needs, like with the diapers, with the food bank, with just sort of basic kind of resources. ... a lot of people have lost their jobs, if not had their hours really limited. People are having to gain second jobs, and third jobs.”

— Physician assistant, HealthySteps Needs Assessment (Sills, 2022a)

Poverty: Concentration, Severity, & Structural Roots

Poverty rate data constitute perhaps the most arresting dimension of the present analysis. The county poverty rate of 15.2 percent, itself not insubstantial, is exceeded in every single target census tract. In some tracts, the poverty rate is more than four times the county average, placing them firmly in the category of “extreme poverty neighborhoods,” defined in the sociological and policy literature as areas where 40 percent or more of the population lives below the federal poverty line (Wilson, 1987; Jargowsky, 1997).

Census Tract 115 in Greensboro records the highest poverty rate in the sample at 60.6 percent, a figure that represents a condition of near-universal economic deprivation for a community of more than 3,600 residents. Tract 139 in High Point (58.1%) and Tract 11202 in Greensboro (56.4%) follow closely, with more than half of all residents in each of these communities living below the poverty line. Tracts 138 (42.8%), 11201 (43.2%), and 114 (36.4%) in Greensboro are in the high-poverty range. Even the relatively lower-poverty tracts in the sample, Tract 143 (18.1%) and Tract 113 (23.5%), exceed the county average.

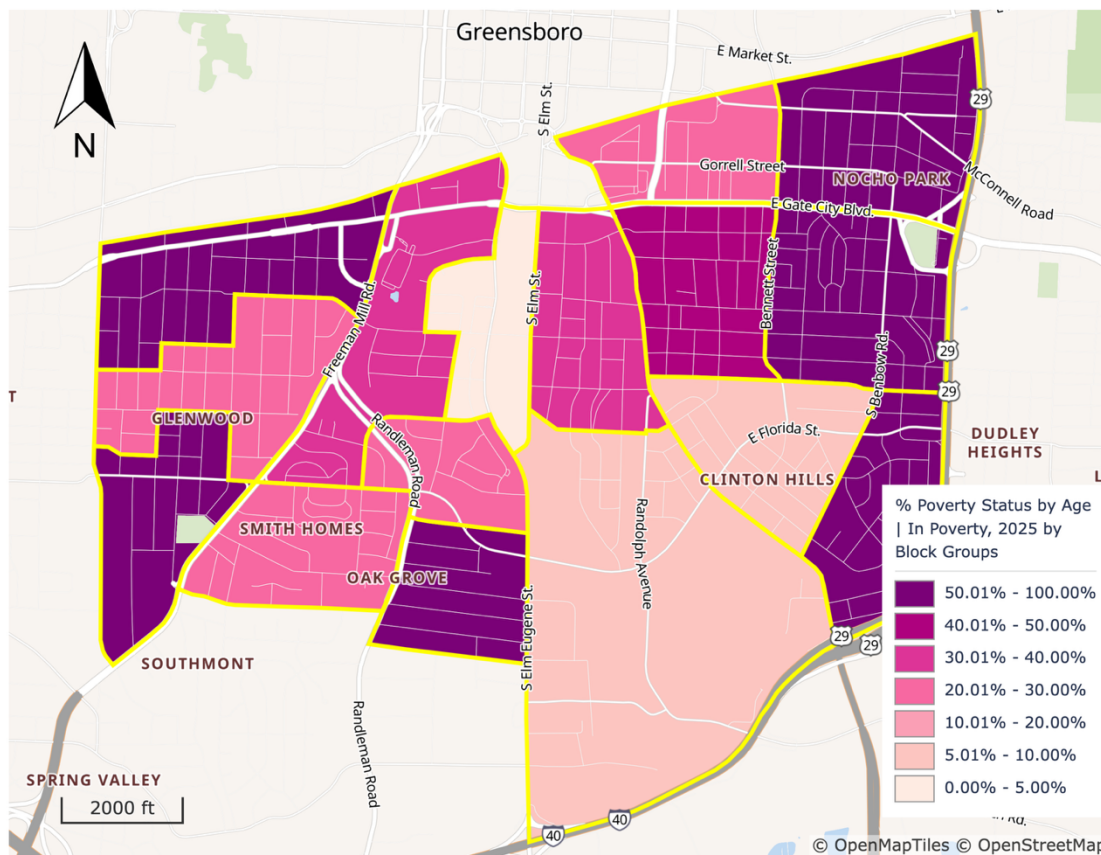


Figure 5 Percent Poverty Greensboro Target Tracts 2025

The sociological significance of concentrated poverty extends well beyond the immediate material deprivation it represents for individual households. Wilson's (1987) foundational work on the truly disadvantaged demonstrated that when poverty becomes spatially concentrated, a set of self-reinforcing social dynamics emerges that compounds disadvantage across multiple life domains. Concentrated poverty is associated with diminished school quality, elevated exposure to crime and violence, reduced access to informal job networks, limited institutional resources, and the erosion of community norms that sustain economic striving (Sampson, 2012; Sharkey, 2013). Place-based disadvantage, as Sharkey (2013) has documented, is transmitted across generations, embedding inequality not merely in individual circumstances but in the fabric of neighborhood life. The poverty rates documented in Tracts 115, 139, and 11202 are not simply statistical artifacts; they describe communities in which the structural conditions for economic advancement have been systematically undermined.

Household income distribution data corroborate the poverty picture. In Tract 139, an estimated 61.1 percent of households report incomes below \$30,000 per year, and 19.4 percent report incomes below \$10,000. In Tract 11201, 50.7 percent of households fall

below the \$30,000 threshold. Tract 11202 (42.0%), Tract 114 (38.9%), Tract 115 (28.3%), and Tract 138 (28.1%) all show substantial concentrations of very low-income households. These figures suggest a neighborhood income structure in which the modal household is operating well below the threshold of economic security, with profound implications for consumption, savings, investment in children, and capacity to weather financial shocks.

Census Tract	Poverty Rate	% HH Income <\$10K	% HH Income <\$30K	% HH Income \$100K+
138 (HP)	42.8%	12.3%	28.1%	3.8%
139 (HP)	58.1%	19.4%	61.1%	1.9%
142 (HP)	35.2%	8.1%	24.9%	20.1%
143 (HP)	18.1%	8.0%	15.9%	17.8%
11201 (GBO)	43.2%	19.9%	50.7%	10.2%
11202 (GBO)	56.4%	11.3%	42.0%	4.4%
113 (GBO)	23.5%	5.7%	21.0%	20.5%
114 (GBO)	36.4%	7.9%	38.9%	13.2%
115 (GBO)	60.6%	12.4%	28.3%	1.7%
Guilford County	15.2%	5.4%	17.4%	37.0%

Table 6. Poverty rate and household income distribution, 2025 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS).

The Long Shadow of Urban Renewal in Tract 139

The extremity of Tract 139's present condition, the lowest median income and highest household poverty concentration in the sample, is not legible without its history. Tract 139 corresponds to the East Central Area of High Point, a historically Black neighborhood that was "consistently recognized as one of the more blighted areas in the city core and was targeted for redevelopment in plans from the 1960s and 1980s, in part based on racial composition of the neighborhood" (Sills, 2023). A 1962 urban renewal plan classified 77 percent of the area's structures, 1,061 buildings, as deficient and recommended acquisition and clearance. A 1986 East Central Small Area Plan renewed the call for revitalization, yet the City Council committed only \$331,179 in Community Development Block Grant funds to the area between 1985 and 1987, a sum that "fell short in meeting the required costs of the recommended development initiatives and housing rehabilitation efforts," with no guarantee of continued funding thereafter (Sills, 2023). The disinvestment recorded in Table 6 is, in this light, the predictable downstream consequence of decades in which the neighborhood was marked for clearance but never adequately reinvested.

Residents understand their economic conditions in precisely these structural terms. In the Resilience High Point assessment, participants connected concentrated poverty directly to crime and violence, with one resident observing of the desperation that scarcity breeds:

“If you take everything from me, I might be willing to steal, to kill.”

— Resident, Resilience High Point Needs Assessment (Sills, 2019)

That same assessment found segregation by race and income recognized by residents themselves as “a root cause of some of the problems discussed in the community,” with the concentration of poverty in the Core City and south High Point producing “low home ownership rates, vacant homes, homelessness, food deserts, and concentrations of health issues and lower life expectancy” (Sills, 2019). The structural reading of poverty advanced by Wilson (1987) and Sampson (2012) is, in these neighborhoods, also the everyday understanding of the people who live there.

Educational Attainment: Credentials & Human Capital Deficit

Educational attainment represents one of the most durable predictors of economic mobility in contemporary American society, and the data for the target census tracts reveal patterns of educational disadvantage that both reflect and reinforce the income and poverty conditions documented above. At the county level, 39.3 percent of residents aged 25 and over hold a bachelor’s degree or higher. In most of the target tracts, this figure is dramatically lower, and in several it is vanishingly small.

Census Tract 143 in High Point records the lowest rate of bachelor’s degree attainment in the sample at 3.6 percent, followed by Tract 139 at 3.9 percent. Tracts 138 (11.1%), 114 (9.3%), and 11202 (19.8%) likewise fall far below the county average. Even the highest-attaining tracts in the sample, 11201 (38.9%) and 115 (26.8%), reflect the differentiated educational composition of these Greensboro neighborhoods, where proximity to higher education institutions (including the North Carolina A&T State University and UNCG corridors) and the presence of student populations may partially explain somewhat elevated attainment rates.

Conversely, rates of educational attainment below the high school level are markedly elevated in the target tracts. Tract 143 reports that 43.9 percent of its adult population lacks a high school diploma, nearly five times the county rate of 9.3 percent. Tracts 139 (33.0%), 11202 (31.2%), 115 (27.6%), 114 (24.4%), 142 (31.1%), and 138 (30.3%) all demonstrate that roughly one-quarter to one-third of adult residents have not attained a high school credential. This pattern is particularly consequential given the documented relationship between educational attainment and labor market access: in an economy that has systematically devalued non-credentialed labor and in which even entry-level positions increasingly require post-secondary credentials or certifications, these communities face a structural barrier to labor market participation that is unlikely to be addressed without

Census Tract	< H.S. Diploma	H.S. Diploma/GED	Some College	Bachelor's+
138 (HP)	30.3%	34.4%	17.5%	11.1%
139 (HP)	33.0%	45.2%	9.9%	3.9%
142 (HP)	31.1%	20.6%	23.9%	13.6%
143 (HP)	43.9%	30.4%	16.5%	3.6%
11201 (GBO)	13.4%	24.2%	14.7%	38.9%
11202 (GBO)	31.2%	21.2%	19.8%	19.8%
113 (GBO)	22.2%	15.4%	36.6%	15.7%
114 (GBO)	24.4%	38.8%	20.9%	9.3%
115 (GBO)	27.6%	31.8%	8.6%	26.8%
Guilford County	9.3%	21.9%	20.3%	39.3%

Table 7. Educational attainment, adults 25+, 2025 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS).

sustained investment in adult education, workforce development, and credentialing pathways (Autor, 2019; Carnevale et al., 2013).

The relationship between educational attainment and immigration status also deserves attention. Several tracts with high Hispanic and immigrant populations, notably Tract 143, record both elevated rates of less-than-high-school attainment and substantial non-citizen populations. This correlation does not imply causation; rather, it reflects the interaction of differential educational systems across countries of origin, differential access to English-language instruction, and the operational definition of “educational attainment” as a credential rather than a measure of knowledge or capability. Adult immigrants with extensive non-U.S. educational experience may be classified as having “less than high school” in U.S. administrative data despite possessing substantial educational accomplishment elsewhere.

The relatively low rates of bachelor’s degree completion in the High Point tracts are particularly noteworthy given the historical relationship between the furniture and textile industries, which historically absorbed large numbers of non-college workers, and educational attainment patterns in High Point’s working-class neighborhoods. As those industries have contracted, the educational profiles of these communities have not kept pace with shifting labor market demands, a form of structural mismatch with severe consequences for economic mobility (Autor, Dorn, & Hanson, 2013).

Workforce research, conducted for the Welfare Reform Liason Project, confirms how these credential gaps translate into exclusion. The Guilford County Workforce Needs Assessment found that even amid employer claims of a worker shortage, jobseekers, particularly people of color, women, justice-involved individuals, and those with limited English proficiency, struggled because “their skills are not aligned with the demands of the current labor market” and because of bias in hiring (Sills, 2022b). The assessment’s recommendations, debt-free

community-college pathways, paid on-the-job training open to adults over 24, and bilingual workforce programming, speak directly to the attainment deficits documented here.

Employment, Labor Force Participation, & Wages

Labor force participation rates measure the proportion of the working-age population (16 and over) that is either employed or actively seeking work. They serve as a critical indicator of community economic vitality and of the structural barriers that prevent full labor market integration. The county labor force participation rate of 64.4 percent provides the relevant benchmark.

The most dramatic departure from this baseline is observed in Census Tract 139 (High Point), where only 30.6 percent of the working-age population is in the labor force, a figure roughly half the county rate. This extraordinary level of labor force detachment is consistent with the tract's poverty profile and age structure (which includes substantial populations in both the 55–64 and elderly categories) and suggests a community in which not merely unemployment but labor market withdrawal has become a dominant pattern. Census Tract 138 (44.9%) and Tract 11201 (47.6%) also reflect significantly depressed labor force participation, as do Tracts 115 (51.7%) and 114 (54.3%). Only Tracts 142 (72.2%), 143 (72.4%), and 113 (68.7%) approach or exceed the county average.

Not-in-labor-force rates reinforce these findings. In Tract 139, 69.3 percent of the working-age population is not in the labor force, a figure that likely reflects a combination of disability, caregiving responsibilities, discouragement, and other structural factors that attenuate labor market engagement. Tract 138 records a not-in-labor-force rate of 54.9 percent, and Tract 11201, 52.3 percent.

Wage data reveal that even among those who are employed, compensation is often inadequate to support economic stability. Median earnings for private-sector workers in Tracts 115 (\$21,372), 11201 (\$22,796), 138 (\$24,268), and 11202 (\$24,725), consistent with employment concentrated in low-wage service, retail, and light manufacturing occupations. The county median for private-sector workers is \$40,086. Tracts 113 (\$37,539) and 114 (\$35,019) perform more closely to the county norm. Self-employment income, a potential pathway to economic self-determination in some community contexts, shows limited presence in most target tracts, with Tract 142 representing a notable exception (\$76,181 median for self-employed incorporated business workers), suggesting a nascent but geographically concentrated entrepreneurial capacity in that neighborhood.

The combination of low labor force participation and depressed wages among those who are employed constitutes a compounding form of economic disadvantage. Communities in which large shares of the working-age population are neither employed nor seeking work,

Census Tract	Labor Force Part. Rate	Not in Labor Force	Pvt. Sector Med. Earnings
138 (HP)	44.9%	54.9%	\$24,268
139 (HP)	30.6%	69.3%	\$26,523
142 (HP)	72.2%	27.7%	\$28,952
143 (HP)	72.4%	27.5%	\$28,654
11201 (GBO)	47.6%	52.3%	\$22,796
11202 (GBO)	60.7%	39.2%	\$24,725
113 (GBO)	68.7%	31.2%	\$37,539
114 (GBO)	54.3%	45.5%	\$35,019
115 (GBO)	51.7%	48.1%	\$21,372
Guilford County	64.4%	35.6%	\$40,086

Table 8. Labor force participation and private-sector wages, 2025 / 2023 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS).

and in which those who are employed earn wages insufficient to escape poverty, face a structural labor market crisis that individual-level job training programs, absent broader wage and economic development strategies, are unlikely to resolve (Pager & Shepherd, 2008; Western & Pettit, 2010).

The Resilience High Point assessment reframed this labor-market crisis as an economic-development imperative rather than a deficit of individual motivation, recommending mentorship, GED, job training, and paid apprenticeships linked across K–12, community college, and economic development so as to “create a pipeline to employment rather than prisons” (Sills, 2019). The geographically concentrated self-employment income observed in Tract 142 hints at latent entrepreneurial capacity that targeted small-business support could formalize and expand.

Housing Tenure, Vacancy, & Neighborhood Stability

Housing is the single largest expenditure category for most American households and the principal vehicle through which intergenerational wealth is accumulated and transmitted (Oliver & Shapiro, 1995). The tenure structure of a neighborhood, the proportion of residents who own their homes versus rent them, is therefore a foundational indicator of both current household economic security and prospective neighborhood wealth-building capacity. The target tracts examined in this report present a tenure structure that is profoundly inverted relative to the county as a whole, with implications that extend across economic development, housing policy, and community stability.

Guilford County records a homeownership rate of 60.4 percent, with 39.6 percent of occupied housing units occupied by renters. The target tract population, by contrast, displays a homeownership rate of only 32.6 percent, with 67.4 percent of occupied units

renter-occupied, a near-perfect inversion of the county pattern. Several individual tracts show even more extreme renter concentrations. Census Tract 11201 (Greensboro) reports only 17.6 percent owner-occupancy, with 82.2 percent of households renting. Tract 139 (High Point) records 23.7 percent owner-occupancy, Tract 115 reports 28.5 percent, and Tract 142 reports 30.5 percent. Only Tract 11202 (45.3 percent) and Tract 138 (42.4 percent) exceed 40 percent owner-occupancy, and none approaches the county rate.

This tenure profile has multiple, compounding consequences. First, renters are structurally more vulnerable to displacement than owners: they can be evicted through formal proceedings or displaced by rent increases, lease non-renewals, and property sales in ways that do not apply to owner-occupants (Desmond, 2016). In neighborhoods where corporate and institutional investors are active in rental property acquisition, a pattern documented extensively in peer metropolitan areas in North Carolina (Raymond et al., 2021; Immergluck, 2018), concentrated renter populations constitute particularly vulnerable populations, subject to accelerated rent increases, deferred maintenance, and elevated eviction filings associated with corporate investor ownership strategies.

Second, the absence of homeownership in these neighborhoods forecloses the principal wealth-building mechanism available to American families and contributes to the persistent racial wealth gap documented by Oliver and Shapiro (1995) and Hamilton and colleagues (2015). Third, renter-majority neighborhoods frequently experience diminished civic participation, lower rates of property maintenance, and weaker neighborhood social networks, not because renters are inherently less committed to their communities, but because the structural conditions of renting in low-income markets generate higher mobility, lower investment incentives, and weaker long-term place attachment.

Housing vacancy data reveal a second dimension of neighborhood stress. The county vacancy rate of 7.8 percent establishes the baseline for normal market function. Several target tracts substantially exceed this rate. Census Tract 11201 records a vacancy rate of 18.2 percent, Tract 115 reports 17.1 percent, and Tract 114 reports 16.1 percent. Tract 143 (14.1 percent) and Tract 142 (13.7 percent) also exceed the county rate. Elevated vacancy reflects a combination of economic abandonment, speculative holding of properties by investors, structural obsolescence of housing stock, and, in some cases, landlord disinvestment in properties that nonetheless generate sufficient rental cash flow to remain profitable.

The economic development implications of elevated vacancy are two-edged. On one hand, concentrated vacancy signals neighborhood distress and undermines the market conditions necessary for private investment. On the other hand, vacant and underutilized properties represent the physical inventory that neighborhood revitalization strategies seek to activate. Vacant commercial properties can be reimagined as small business incubation

Census Tract	Housing Units	% Vacant	% Owner Occ.	% Renter Occ.
138 (HP)	1,565	5.8%	42.4%	57.4%
139 (HP)	2,240	10.2%	23.8%	76.1%
142 (HP)	1,825	13.7%	30.6%	69.3%
143 (HP)	1,320	14.1%	33.5%	66.3%
11201 (GBO)	1,480	18.2%	17.6%	82.2%
11202 (GBO)	1,361	9.4%	45.3%	54.5%
113 (GBO)	1,939	4.6%	40.2%	59.6%
114 (GBO)	2,355	16.1%	31.4%	68.4%
115 (GBO)	1,350	17.1%	28.5%	71.2%
Target Area	15,435	12.0%	32.6%	67.4%
Guilford County	239,386	7.8%	60.4%	39.6%

Table 9. Housing units, vacancy, and tenure, 2025 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS).

spaces; vacant residential units can be rehabilitated and returned to productive use through community land trust structures, nonprofit developers, or targeted public investment; mixed-use properties in neighborhood commercial corridors can anchor commercial revitalization. The AI-assisted analysis of business activation opportunities in vacant spaces, which represents a parallel strand of IRI's current work, is particularly well-positioned to identify and prioritize these opportunities across the target tract geography. Previous IRI research on commercial corridors such as Washington Street in High Point has documented the capacity of data-driven vacancy analysis to inform targeted reinvestment strategies.

Behind the tenure inversion lies acute housing precarity. The Resilience High Point assessment found that more than half of High Point renters are cost-burdened, paying more than 30 percent of income toward rent, placing roughly 10,000 households at risk of eviction from a single unforeseen shock such as a car repair, hospitalization, or high utility bill (Sills, 2019). Pediatric providers in the HealthySteps study described the health consequences of substandard rental housing in stark terms:

“It’s the basics of housing... the environment of the housing is very poor. I have several kids, actually, in my practice, who have had, like, severe eczema. And we found that the house had bedbugs, there was mold in the house, and then we fought to get new housing for them. And all of a sudden, I’m not prescribing them some of the medications that they needed. It just was so sad that some of these were directly linked to their well-being... in such a very strong, adverse way.”

— Pediatrician, HealthySteps Needs Assessment (Sills, 2022a)

Another provider described how housing instability forecloses every other intervention: “when [housing insecurity] is an issue... it is difficult for me to put anything else on their list...

if they're not housed or in school or employed, then they don't qualify for a voucher" (Sills, 2022a). For these neighborhoods, the renter majorities and elevated vacancy documented in Table 9 are also the conditions that make them prime targets for the corporate-investor acquisition that IRI's parallel methodological work is designed to detect and counter.

Transportation Access & Spatial Mobility

Access to reliable transportation is a prerequisite for labor market participation in most urban environments, where job opportunities are geographically distributed in ways that rarely align with residential patterns in low-income neighborhoods. Vehicle availability data for the target census tracts reveal significant transportation vulnerabilities that compound labor market and economic access barriers documented elsewhere in this analysis.

Census Tract 139 (High Point) records the highest rate of vehicle inaccessibility in the sample: 44.3 percent of households have no vehicle available, compared to 6.9 percent countywide. Tracts 114 (30.2%), 138 (25.8%), and 11201 (28.3%) follow with approximately one-quarter to one-third of households lacking vehicular transportation. In communities where public transit coverage may be limited, a characteristic of many mid-size North Carolina cities, such rates of vehicle inaccessibility represent a severe structural constraint on access to employment, healthcare, grocery stores, and other essential services (Blumenberg & Manville, 2004).

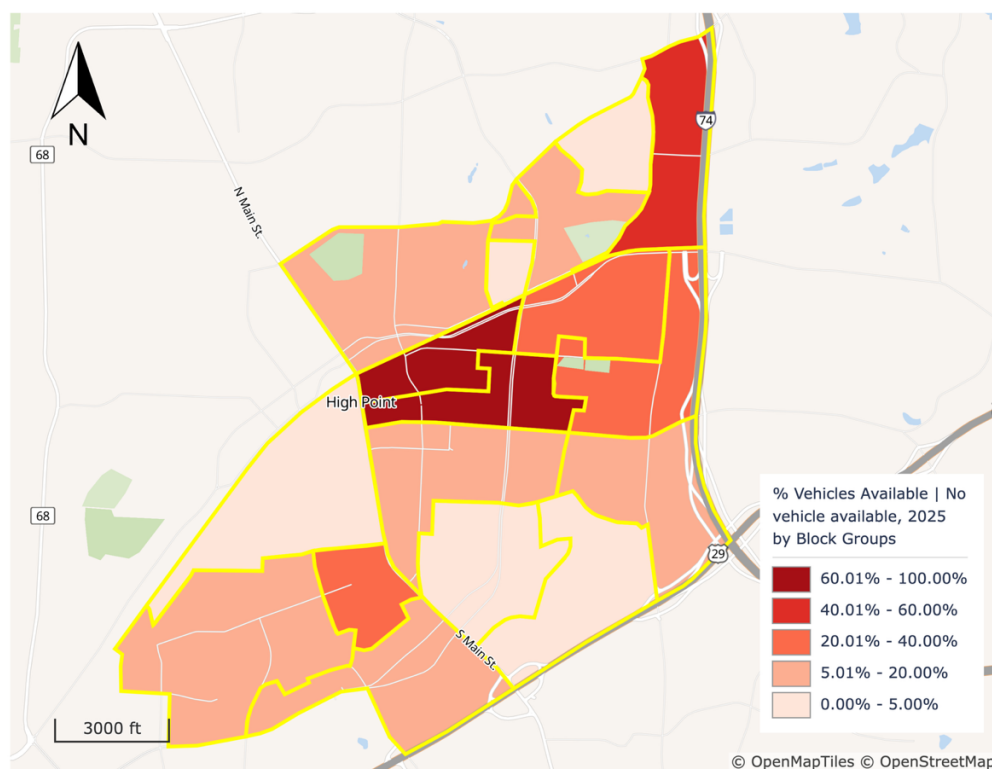


Figure 6 Percent of Households without Vehicle 2025 High Point, NC

Transportation expenditure data from 2022 provide a complementary perspective. Households in Tract 11201 spend an average of \$8,236 on transportation annually, well below the county average of \$13,065. Low transportation expenditure, in contexts of very low income and high vehicle inaccessibility, may reflect a combination of transit dependence and foregone trips, rather than genuine cost efficiency. At the other end of the spectrum, households in Tracts 142 and 113 spend approximately \$12,000 per year on transportation, costs that represent a substantial burden as a share of income in neighborhoods where median household income may be only \$50,000–\$55,000.

The intersection of vehicle inaccessibility with labor market geography deserves particular attention. As Blumenberg and Manville (2004) have documented, the spatial mismatch between low-income urban neighborhoods and suburban employment centers is substantially mediated by transportation access: residents without vehicles face dramatically reduced effective labor market catchment areas, constraining both the number and quality of jobs accessible to them. In Guilford County’s geographic context, where manufacturing, healthcare, and logistics employment is distributed across industrial corridors not uniformly served by transit, vehicle inaccessibility represents a concrete structural barrier to economic mobility for significant shares of the target tract populations.

Census Tract	% No Vehicle	Avg. Transportation Expenditure	Poverty Rate
138 (HP)	25.8%	\$10,390	42.8%
139 (HP)	44.3%	\$10,863	58.1%
142 (HP)	9.6%	\$12,011	35.2%
143 (HP)	14.5%	\$11,443	18.1%
11201 (GBO)	28.3%	\$8,236	43.2%
11202 (GBO)	10.9%	\$11,737	56.4%
113 (GBO)	4.3%	\$12,010	23.5%
114 (GBO)	30.2%	\$10,274	36.4%
115 (GBO)	17.8%	\$11,125	60.6%
Guilford County	6.9%	\$13,065	15.2%

Table 10. Vehicle access and transportation expenditure, 2025 / 2022 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS).

Front-line providers describe transportation as among the most binding constraints families face. A High Point clinic worker explained that “transportation is one that I think it’s really huge here in High Point... we have a lot of cancellations and no shows because transportation, it’s a huge need here” (Sills, 2022a). Because many specialty referrals require travel to Winston-Salem, families without cars are effectively cut off from advanced care: “you can’t get to [it] by bus... [Medicaid transportation] takes eight hours to handle all that” (Sills, 2022a). The Resilience High Point assessment accordingly recommended

subsidized or free 30-day transit passes for families in target neighborhoods, paired with SNAP/EBT benefits, as an immediate, high-leverage intervention (Sills, 2019).

Household Expenditures & Material Deprivation

Expenditure data provide a window into the lived experience of household resource management at different income levels, and into the ways in which poverty constrains not merely discretionary spending but access to basic necessities. Food expenditure figures, in particular, serve as a reliable proxy for material deprivation, since low-income households tend to spend a higher share of their income on food even as they spend less in absolute terms.

Average annual household food expenditure in Census Tract 11201 (\$4,480) is the lowest in the sample and substantially below the county average of \$7,193. This figure is consistent with a community in which a significant share of households are food insecure, relying on food assistance programs, food banks, and informal support networks to supplement inadequate food budgets. Tracts 139 (\$5,998) and 114 (\$6,076) also record food expenditures substantially below the county average. The modest food budgets observed across the target tracts should not be interpreted as efficient household management; rather, they reflect constrained consumption driven by income insufficiency, with well-documented consequences for nutritional adequacy, health outcomes, and child development (Coleman-Jensen et al., 2022).

Utility expenditure data (housing utilities, fuels, and public services) reveal that households across the target tracts spend between \$3,043 (Tract 11201) and \$4,898 (Tract 113) annually on utilities, figures broadly lower than the county average of \$5,052. As a share of household income, however, utility costs represent a disproportionate burden in low-income tracts. A household in Tract 139 spending \$4,231 per year on utilities while reporting a median household income of \$17,692 is allocating approximately 24 percent of gross household income to utilities alone, a burden that leaves little margin for food, transportation, healthcare, or savings.

Other household operation expenditures, covering child care, housekeeping services, home maintenance, and related costs, average between \$891 (Tract 11201) and \$1,535 (Tract 113) annually. The low household operation expenditures in the most distressed tracts reflect not merely low demand but absence of resources to pay for services that middle-income households access routinely, including child care arrangements that would otherwise enable caretakers to participate in the labor force.

Census Tract	Avg. Food Exp.	Avg. Utilities Exp.	Avg. HH Ops. Exp.
138 (HP)	\$6,481	\$4,538	\$1,356
139 (HP)	\$5,998	\$4,231	\$1,291
142 (HP)	\$6,935	\$4,811	\$1,471
143 (HP)	\$6,856	\$4,424	\$1,336
11201 (GBO)	\$4,480	\$3,043	\$891
11202 (GBO)	\$6,619	\$4,557	\$1,367
113 (GBO)	\$7,297	\$4,898	\$1,535
114 (GBO)	\$6,076	\$4,328	\$1,335
115 (GBO)	\$6,569	\$4,577	\$1,422
Guilford County	\$7,193	\$5,052	\$1,591

Table 11. Average annual household expenditure categories, 2022 (Consumer Expenditure Survey).

The constrained food budgets in Table 11 register, in the words of residents, as a persistent condition of scarcity rather than thrift. One participant in the Guilford County Food Study described the daily calculus directly:

“Food insecurity affects myself and the people close to me in our everyday lives. Whether that be depending on SNAP benefits for assistance or simply living paycheck to paycheck, there’s this air of scarcity that can’t be pushed under the rug. Oftentimes we are forced to prioritize making sure there is food on the table over investing in things that would bring us joy or mental wellness.”

— Community participant, Guilford County Food Study (Innovative Research Insights, 2025a)

The same study documented how rigid program rules exclude families who are nominally over-income yet materially struggling, “If you don’t fit within a certain criterion... I have parents who don’t qualify for anything, and they’re barely making ends meet”, and how benefit cliffs strand seniors, who described eligibility stipulations as not “senior-friendly” (Innovative Research Insights, 2025a). Food pantries, the safety net of last resort, reported being unable to meet demand. These dynamics are visible at the neighborhood anchor level as well: newly installed intake systems at the Macedonia Family Resource Center revealed that “50% of clients come in for food services” (Innovative Research Insights, 2025b), a measurable index of the material deprivation that the low food-expenditure figures only imply.

Digital Equity & the Technology Access Divide

In the contemporary digital economy, internet access is not a luxury amenity but an infrastructure of basic economic and civic participation, a prerequisite for job applications, telehealth services, online education, government services, and small business operation. The county internet

subscription rate of 94.4 percent reflects near-universal access in the county as a whole; however, access rates in several target census tracts fall meaningfully short of this benchmark.

Census Tract 143 (High Point) records the lowest internet subscription rate in the sample at 74.4 percent, followed by Tracts 138 (76.8%) and 113 (77.8%). While these figures do not represent the most extreme digital divides in national perspective, a 20-percentage-point gap between target tract access rates and the county norm implies that a substantial number of households in these communities are navigating economic, civic, and educational life without reliable internet access, a form of digital exclusion with increasingly severe economic consequences as more services and economic transactions migrate online (van Dijk, 2020; Whitacre et al., 2014).

Tracts 11202 (96.8%), 115 (91.3%), and 114 (90.9%) report internet subscription rates closer to the county average, suggesting more heterogeneous digital access conditions across the target geography. Nonetheless, even in relatively higher-access tracts, an internet subscription rate of 91 percent implies that 9 percent of households, several hundred families in a tract of 3,000–5,000 people, are navigating an increasingly digital world without reliable connectivity.

The digital divide intersects with poverty, age, educational attainment, linguistic background, and housing stability in ways that compound disadvantage. Households that lack internet access are disproportionately concentrated among the lowest income quintiles, among elderly residents, among non-English-speaking households, and among renters in unstable housing situations, demographic groups that are overrepresented in the target census tracts.

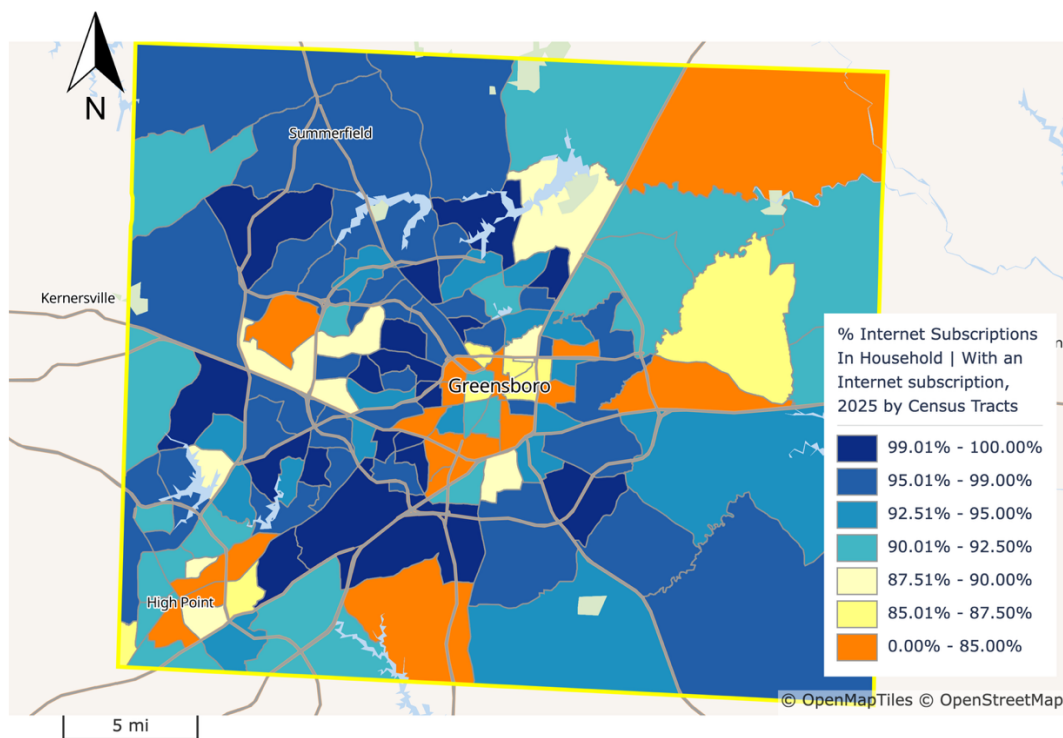


Figure 7 Internet Subscriptions by Household Guilford County, NC

The combination of high renter rates, substantial Spanish-speaking populations, and elevated vacancy in tracts such as 143 creates a layered digital inclusion challenge. Closing the digital divide in these communities will require not merely infrastructure investment but subsidized access programs, digital literacy training, linguistically accessible instructional materials, and device provision, a comprehensive package of digital inclusion interventions that must be integrated into any serious economic development strategy (Federal Communications Commission, 2020).

The scale of the challenge is corroborated by prior IRI work in High Point, where roughly 19 percent of households were found to lack internet access, concentrated in the central and southern core (Sills, 2022a). In a setting where physical access to clinics, banks, and employment services is already constrained by the transportation barriers documented above, broadband functions as a substitute mobility infrastructure, one that is more affordable to provide and more equitably distributable than physical transit.

Racial Disparities in Income & Opportunity

Guilford County's racial income gap is substantial and well-documented. County-level data reveal a median household income for Black residents of \$50,461, approximately 61 percent of the White non-Hispanic median of \$83,425. This 39-percentage-point racial income gap reflects the legacy of formally sanctioned racial discrimination in employment, housing, and education, as well as the continuing effects of structural racism in contemporary labor and housing markets (Rothstein, 2017; Pager & Shepherd, 2008; Hamilton et al., 2015). The racial composition data presented earlier in this report, in which target tracts are 59.7 percent Black compared to 33.9 percent countywide, situates these income gaps spatially: the neighborhoods that house disproportionate shares of the county's Black population are precisely those in which the material consequences of the racial income gap are most concentrated.

Within the target census tracts, racial income data reveal additional complexity and, in some cases, acute disparities. In Census Tract 138 (High Point), a striking and counterintuitive pattern emerges: the estimated White non-Hispanic median household income of \$15,591 is actually lower than the Black median of \$42,530. This pattern, while surprising at first glance, is consistent with the presence of a small White non-Hispanic population in the tract that is disproportionately represented among the most economically marginalized residents, perhaps including elderly residents on fixed incomes or non-family households. It does not represent a straightforward reversal of the racial income hierarchy; rather, it reflects the demographic complexity of a predominantly Black neighborhood in which poverty cuts across racial lines.

More characteristic patterns are observed in Tracts 114 and 11202, where Black median household incomes of \$32,086 and \$31,419 respectively reflect incomes consistent with the broader pattern of economic disadvantage documented for these neighborhoods. The limited availability of White non-Hispanic income data for some tracts (where population shares are too small for reliable estimates) itself reflects the demographic composition of several target communities, which are predominantly or heavily Black, a pattern consistent with the spatial concentration of racial minority populations documented by Massey and Denton (1993) and with the ongoing effects of residential segregation in Guilford County's urban neighborhoods.

The racial dimensions of concentrated poverty in these communities cannot be separated from the history of racial exclusion in housing markets, employment, and public investment that shaped the spatial distribution of poverty in the first place. From the racial restrictive covenants that limited Black homeownership in Greensboro and High Point through the mid-twentieth century, to the urban renewal projects that displaced Black communities from commercially viable land, to the redlining practices that denied mortgage credit to Black homebuyers in segregated neighborhoods, the geography of disadvantage documented in this analysis is, in significant measure, the geography of racial exclusion given spatial form (Rothstein, 2017; Massey & Denton, 1993). The present concentration of renter-occupied housing in majority-Black target tracts, and the parallel concentration of owner-occupied housing in majority-White suburban areas, is a continuation rather than a departure from this historical pattern. Any serious equity-focused economic development strategy must grapple with these historical roots.

Census Tract	Black Median HH Income	White NH Median HH Income	% Black Population
138 (HP)	\$42,530	\$15,591	54.8%
139 (HP)	\$19,156	N/A	72.1%
142 (HP)	\$53,277	\$46,798	27.1%
143 (HP)	\$42,022	\$36,936	29.1%
11201 (GBO)	N/A	\$62,443	64.1%
11202 (GBO)	\$31,419	N/A	82.7%
113 (GBO)	\$50,875	N/A	81.1%
114 (GBO)	\$32,086	N/A	62.0%
115 (GBO)	\$41,086	\$37,169	59.4%
Guilford County	\$50,461	\$83,425	33.9%

Table 12. Racial household income disparities, 2025 (SimplyAnalytics / ACS). N/A = population too small for reliable estimate.

The income gaps recorded in Table 12 are the economic register of disparities that extend across health, environment, and opportunity. The racialized planning literature synthesized in the introduction documents how these gaps were produced and sustained, and how they materialize in the health of residents (Sills, 2021, 2023). In High Point, African American infants experience roughly double the mortality rate of non-Hispanic white infants, and the opioid death rate for Black residents rose 154 percent between 2015 and 2020 (Sills, 2023). Environmental disadvantage tracks the same geography: a 2020 study of Census Tract 143, one of the tracts profiled here, found that 50 percent of homes tested exceeded federal standards for mercury and 25 percent for lead, contaminants associated with aging infrastructure in older, lower-income neighborhoods of color (Sills, 2023). Within High Point as a whole, life expectancy varies by as much as 17 years depending on the neighborhood of residence (Sills, 2023).

Residents perceive this geography of inequity clearly and describe the deliberate inattention that sustains it. In the Resilience High Point assessment, one resident observed that “most in north High Point live in a cocoon. Consciously or unconsciously, they ignore the issues that plague other citizens of the city,” while a resident of south High Point described:

“a diverse community of seniors and young families that are praying someone, anyone, will speak to us about the inequities, we experience daily.”

— Resident of south High Point, Resilience High Point Needs Assessment (Sills, 2019)

Economic Development Opportunities & Investment Priorities

The demographic and socioeconomic profile documented in the preceding sections presents a challenging but not hopeless landscape for place-based economic development. Several features of the target tract data suggest potential entry points for strategic public and private investment, and the Guilford County Data Atlas initiative is well-positioned to identify, systematize, and communicate these opportunities to county leadership, community partners, and prospective investors.

Workforce Development & Educational Investment

The prevalence of sub-baccalaureate educational attainment across the target tracts, with rates of less-than-high-school completion ranging from 13.4 percent to 43.9 percent, points to a substantial unmet need for adult basic education, GED completion services, and short-cycle workforce credentialing programs. Community colleges, workforce development boards, and community-based organizations operating in these neighborhoods represent critical institutional anchors for human capital investment. The relatively modest wage premium associated with private-sector employment in most target tracts suggests that credentialing in higher-wage fields, healthcare, skilled trades, advanced manufacturing,

information technology, represents a more promising pathway to wage growth than additional low-wage service sector employment. The presence of substantial Spanish-speaking populations in Tracts 143, 11201, and 115 further suggests the need for bilingual or Spanish-language workforce development pathways.

The entrepreneurial activity suggested by the elevated self-employment earnings in Tract 142, where median self-employed incorporated business income reaches \$76,181, suggests that at least some portion of the target tract population has demonstrated capacity for formal business ownership. Targeted small business development programming, microfinance access, and business incubation, modeled on successful initiatives such as the Genesis Block entrepreneurship hub in Wilmington, NC, could serve to expand and formalize entrepreneurial activity in communities where it currently remains underdeveloped relative to latent demand.

Community partners frame this priority in terms of investment rather than charity. Reflecting on what neighborhood institutions most need, one Macedonia stakeholder distilled the principle directly, “Don’t give me money. Invest in me”, and urged a renewed, logistics-minded connection to Guilford Technical Community College (transportation, co-located classes) to convert workforce aspiration into repeatable pathways (Innovative Research Insights, 2025b). The Guilford County Workforce Needs Assessment similarly recommends debt-free community-college options and paid on-the-job training linked to industry and open to adults over 24 (Sills, 2022b).

Housing Stability, Homeownership, & Anti-Displacement Strategy

The structural inversion of the tenure profile in the target tracts, with renter-majorities as high as 82 percent, represents both a condition of vulnerability and a field of intervention. Given the prevalence of corporate investor homebuying in comparable North Carolina markets (Raymond et al., 2021; Immergluck, 2018), the renter-dominant target tracts constitute prime geographies for corporate investor activity, with the attendant risks of accelerated rent increases, displacement, and neighborhood destabilization.

The multi-institutional corporate investor analysis underway through IRI’s Project 2, building on the UNC Charlotte methodology developed for Mecklenburg County, will provide empirical grounding for policy responses including tenant protection ordinances, right-of-first-refusal requirements, community land trusts, and targeted affordable homeownership programming designed to shift tenure balance in these neighborhoods over time. The exceptionally low homeownership rate in Tract 11201 (17.6 percent), combined with its substantial non-citizen population and elevated vacancy, suggests particular vulnerability warranting prioritized attention.

Transportation & Mobility Infrastructure

Vehicle inaccessibility rates of 25–44 percent in several target tracts, combined with the spatial distribution of employment in Guilford County, represent a critical structural barrier to labor market participation. Public transit investments, including route coverage, frequency, and hours of service in corridors connecting target neighborhoods to major employment centers, alongside mobility support programs such as vehicle acquisition assistance and ride-sharing subsidies, represent high-leverage public investments with direct labor market access benefits.

Commercial Corridor & Business District Revitalization

Several target census tracts contain or abut commercial corridors that have experienced sustained disinvestment, vacant storefronts, underutilized commercial properties, and deteriorated streetscapes that both reflect and compound neighborhood economic decline. The elevated residential vacancy rates documented in Tracts 11201, 115, 114, 143, and 142 likely correlate with commercial vacancy patterns in adjacent commercial frontages. Systematic identification of vacant and underutilized commercial and mixed-use properties in these corridors, combined with analysis of business activation potential using AI-assisted market analysis tools, represents a promising approach to identifying opportunities for strategic commercial reinvestment. The Guilford County Data Atlas framework is well-suited to this task, providing the neighborhood-level data infrastructure needed to make the case for targeted investment to prospective developers, lenders, and public sector partners.

The Washington Street corridor in High Point illustrates both the loss and the latent opportunity. Once the commercial heart of the city’s Black community, the four-block district has, in the language of recent city plans, seen many of its buildings “lost to demolition” and now “suffers from a lack of investment”; yet residents and planners alike express “broad consensus that the corridor can once again serve as a ‘Black Wall Street’” (Innovative Research Insights, 2025). Data-driven identification of activation opportunities, paired with community-centered redevelopment that avoids displacement, is precisely the work the Atlas is designed to support.

Culturally and Linguistically Responsive Service Delivery

The linguistic and demographic diversity of the target tracts, particularly the substantial Hispanic and immigrant populations in Tracts 143, 11201, 115, and 138, requires that economic development interventions be designed with linguistic and cultural accessibility at their core. Bilingual outreach, culturally competent technical assistance, immigrant-friendly small business support, and partnerships with community-based organizations

serving specific populations are essential components of an equitable strategy. The presence of established immigrant populations with documented entrepreneurial inclinations also represents an untapped economic development asset: immigrant entrepreneurs have consistently been shown in the sociological and economic literature to generate disproportionate rates of small business formation, particularly in ethnic enclaves with developed co-ethnic consumer markets (Portes & Rumbaut, 2014).

Digital Inclusion as Economic Infrastructure

Closing the digital access gap in Tracts 138, 143, and 113, where one in five or more households lack internet access, should be understood as economic infrastructure investment rather than merely a social service. Access to reliable broadband enables remote work, online commerce, online education, telehealth, and digital financial services. In communities where physical access to banks, libraries, employment services, and healthcare may be constrained, internet access functions as a substitute transportation infrastructure, one that is more affordable to provide and more equitably distributable than physical mobility infrastructure.

Toward a Framework for Equitable Investment

The data analyzed in this report describe nine communities in Guilford County that share a common structural condition: they have been systematically excluded from the economic development processes and public investments that have produced prosperity elsewhere in the county and the region. Majority-Black demographic composition, substantial Hispanic and immigrant populations, poverty rates ranging from 18 to 61 percent, median household incomes as low as \$17,692, labor force participation rates as low as 30.6 percent, rates of less-than-high-school educational attainment exceeding 40 percent, homeownership rates as low as 17.6 percent, housing vacancy rates exceeding 18 percent, and vehicle inaccessibility affecting more than a quarter of households in several tracts, these are not random variations in a well-functioning market. They are the legible traces of decades of racialized disinvestment, market abandonment, and inadequate public response.

At the same time, the data reveal a landscape not of uniform deprivation but of considerable internal differentiation. Some tracts, notably 143 in High Point and 113 in Greensboro, present a somewhat more mixed economic profile, with lower poverty rates and modestly higher incomes suggesting a potentially different trajectory. Others, Tracts 115, 139, and 11202, present conditions of concentrated disadvantage severe enough to require systemic, multi-sectoral interventions if meaningful economic improvement is to be achieved within a policy-relevant time horizon. Still others, notably Tract 11201, with its

substantial immigrant population, extraordinarily young age profile, and very low homeownership, present distinct demographic conditions requiring tailored interventions calibrated to the particular circumstances of that community.

The Guilford County Data Atlas initiative represents a critically important first step: documenting these conditions rigorously, making the data accessible to community partners and policymakers, and building the evidentiary foundation for targeted investment. The Atlas's utility will depend on its capacity not merely to describe current conditions but to track change over time, to identify specific intervention opportunities within the target tracts, and to connect neighborhood-level data to the broader institutional and policy landscape within which economic development occurs.

Sociological theory and empirical evidence converge on a clear conclusion: place-based interventions, investments in specific neighborhoods rather than merely in individual residents, are necessary components of any serious strategy for reducing concentrated disadvantage. Neighborhood conditions shape individual life chances in ways that individual-level programs cannot fully address (Sampson, 2012; Sharkey, 2013; Chetty et al., 2016). The nine census tracts examined in this report are neighborhoods in which place itself has become a mechanism of disadvantage. Reversing that dynamic will require sustained, coordinated, equity-centered investment, investment informed by precisely the kind of rigorous community data analysis that this initiative is designed to support.

Such investment is best understood, finally, not as charity but as repair. The companion analysis in "From Disparity to Parity" frames the path forward in the language of restorative justice: acknowledgment of the harm caused by past and present injustice, legal and policy reform to dismantle discriminatory structures, and targeted investment in education, housing, and economic opportunity in the historically Black neighborhoods that bore the cost of racialized planning (Sills, 2023). Where the structural conditions documented in this report were produced by deliberate decisions about where capital would flow and where it would be withheld, the work of reversing them is equally a matter of deliberate, equity-centered choice. As that analysis concludes, the cost of inaction "is being felt by health systems, schools, employers, public housing, and policing agencies in every municipality in the South," and "to do nothing and allow the status quo to continue is no longer an option" (Sills, 2023). The Guilford County Data Atlas exists to make the better choice both legible and actionable.

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